



ANGOLA

Capital city: Luanda
Area: 481,351 sq miles (1,246,700 sq km)
Population: 13,600,000
Official language: Portuguese
Major religions: Christian 70%, other 30%
Government: Transitional government
Currency: New kwanza
Adult literacy rate: 40%
Life expectancy: 47 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 14 per 1,000 people



- Major towns
- Benguela railroad

The Benguela railroad runs from the coastal ports of Benguela and Lobito in Angola eastward until reaching Zaire.

ANGOLA

ANGOLA SHOULD BE ONE of the most successful countries in Africa. The land is largely fertile, with dense tropical forests in the north giving way to drier grasslands in the south. Farmers produce enough food to support the small population, while huge oil and mineral reserves bring wealth to the economy. However, Angola has been torn apart by a civil war that began in 1975. Few parts of the country have been left unaffected by the fighting, which has killed or injured thousands of people and reduced this potentially rich country to poverty.



BENGUELA RAILROAD

Opened in 1931, the Benguela railroad was built to transport copper and other minerals from the mines of landlocked Zambia and the Congo to the coastal ports of Lobito and Benguela for export around the world. The railroad and ports provided work for many Angolans, who lost their jobs when the railroad was destroyed in the civil war. After the ceasefire of 1991, engineers began to rebuild sections of the track, and plans have been made to reopen the railroad.



CIVIL WAR

In 1975, Portuguese rule in Angola ended and civil war broke out. The conflict was between the Angolan People's Liberation Movement (MPLA), supported by the Soviet Union and Cuba, and the National Union for Total Angolan Independence (UNITA), supported by South Africa and the US. After a ceasefire in 1991, the MPLA was elected to power, but fighting broke out again. A ceasefire in 2002 has now brought some peace to this shattered land.



LUANDA

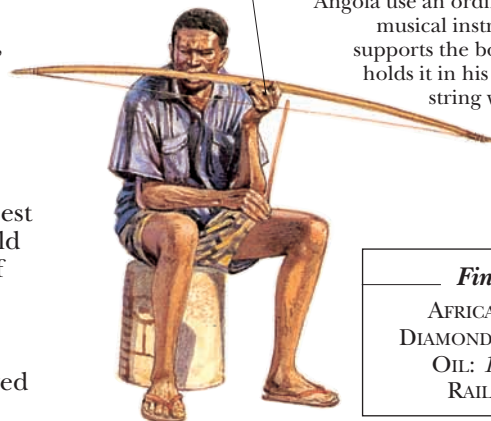
The port of Luanda is Angola's capital and biggest city. Founded by the Portuguese in 1576, for centuries it was a center for shipping slaves to the Portuguese colony of Brazil. The Portuguese built a fort and many other fine buildings, which stand alongside modern skyscrapers. On the hills surrounding the city vast shantytowns house thousands of people.



INDUSTRY

The tiny Angolan territory of Cabinda, to the north of the main part of the country, is one of the richest oil-producing regions in Africa. Offshore oil fields contain reserves of 1.5 billion barrels of oil and vast quantities of natural gas. Some of the richest diamond deposits in the world are found in the northeast of the country, while iron and other minerals are mined farther south. However, constant fighting has destroyed some mines and factories.

A brace divides the bow string into two unequal lengths.



MUSICAL BOW

The Humbi people of southwestern Angola use an ordinary hunting bow as a musical instrument. The musician supports the bow with one hand and holds it in his mouth. As he hits the string with a stick held in his other hand, he produces different notes by altering the shape of his lips.

Find out more

AFRICAN CITIES: 206
DIAMONDS: 150, 226, 248
OIL: 152, 230, 281
RAILROADS: 245